The Life You *Choose*

THE MADE REAL BLUEPRINT / STEP 1

I stay in the town I know, *and I get my evenings back.*

I work four days, and the fifth day is outdoors. I am outside every day, even when the weather is bad.

Sam · In the first week

01 Picture — 02 Explore — 03 Decide

MY WORKING DIRECTION

What I am choosing between

A

Four days a week here, Friday outdoors

Not sure yet: Whether my manager agrees, and whether four-fifths pay is comfortable

B

Move somewhere greener and cheaper

Not sure yet: Whether I would still have anybody to eat with

What I want to protect

My job and the people in it. My flat and the rent I can afford. My sister ten minutes away. The Thursday market. Knowing the chemist by name.

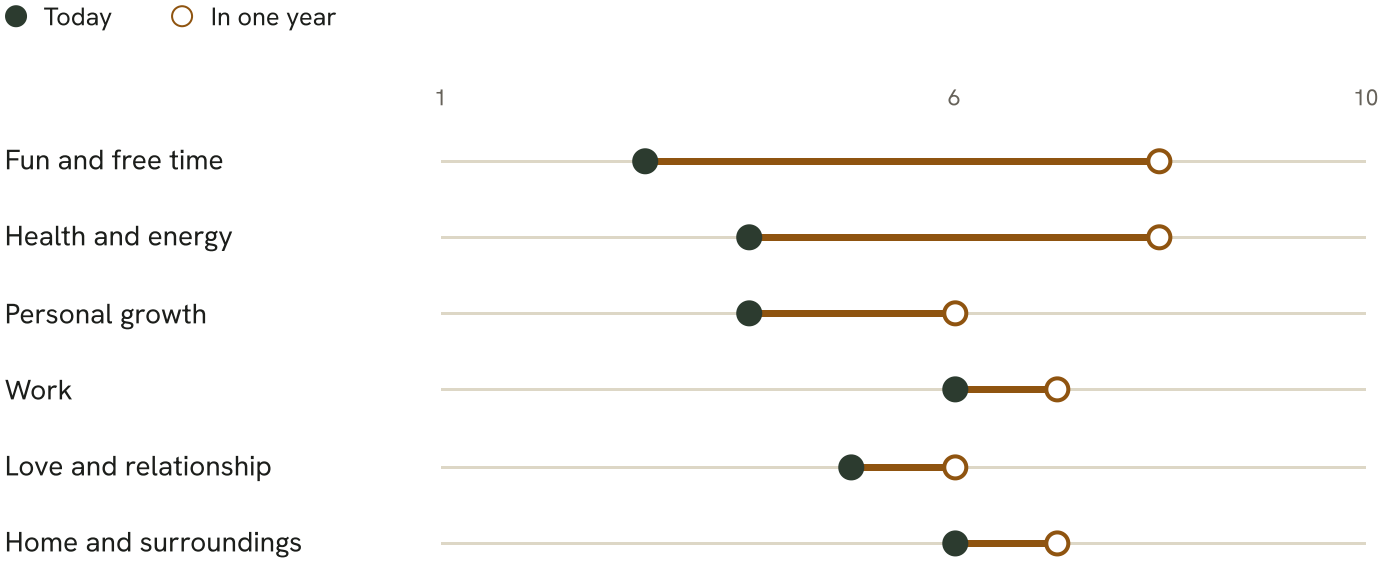
HEALTH · FREEDOM · FAMILY · NATURE · SIMPLICITY

Build the life I want where I am. Let go for now: A fifth of my pay, evening email, and the idea that the life I want is abroad.

MY STARTING POINT

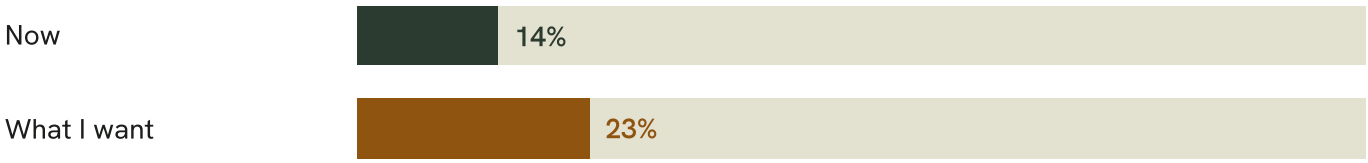
What I want more of

Nine hours a day in an office, two of them on things that could wait. Sixteen hours a week that are mine. A flat I like, with no outside space, in a town I do not want to leave.



My own scores, 1–10. The second mark is where I want to be in a year, not something already achieved.

TIME I DECIDE FOR MYSELF



16 of my 112 waking hours a week are mine to choose. The second figure is what I am aiming at.

THE FIRST BLOCK I TAKE BACK

Two evenings a week to start, then the whole of Friday. That is about ten hours back, every week.

I keep small promises. I am good at the work. I know everyone in three streets.

MONEY AND MOMENTUM

A first money picture

These are my own figures for a month in the new life, and the income I can count on.

Monthly costs **€2,210**



Income I can count on **€2,360**



€150 left over each month

On the costs and income recorded here.

€690 is recorded for the change itself. €6,710 is left to live on after the one-time costs, deposits and a €6,600 reserve.

WHAT MY NEW LIFE MUST GIVE ME

Daylight after work, most days · One whole day a week outdoors · Rent I can pay without counting · My sister within half an hour · Work I am good at · A patch of ground of my own

MY NEXT SMALL STEP, WITHIN TWO WEEKS

No work after six on Tuesday and Thursday, for four weeks.

Questions to settle: That my manager will discuss four days at all. That I can live on four-fifths of my pay. That I will actually go outside when the evening is free.

REVIEW / IN 8 WEEKS

If I am outside on most of those evenings, I ask for the four-day week. If I work through them anyway, the hours are not the problem, and I look at the job instead.

Dealbreakers I carry forward: A week with no daylight in it. Moving away from my sister. Rent I have to think about on the first of the month.